

The Meat Between Your Teeth: When God Says "Yes" to Your Ruin

Key Verse: Numbers 11:33 (KJV) – "And while the flesh was yet between their teeth, ere it was chewed, the wrath of the LORD was kindled against the people, and the LORD smote the people with a very great plague."

Sadly, there is a prayer that God answers not because He is pleased, but because He is provoked. There is a craving so deep, so rebellious, that the Lord will open His hand and give you exactly what you scream for—not to bless you, but to break you. We have built our theology on the sunny side of the street: "Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find." (Matthew 7:7, KJV). And that is true—but it is not the whole truth. For there is another asking, a dark asking, a asking born not of faith but of fever, and when that prayer reaches heaven, God may grant it with a fury that masquerades as favor. We come to Numbers chapter eleven, and we find the children of Israel in the wilderness—not in Egypt, not yet in Canaan, but in that terrible in-between where memory becomes a liar and the present becomes unbearable. They had seen the plagues. They had walked through the Red Sea on dry ground. They had eaten the manna, that angel's food that fell with the dew. They had seen the pillar of cloud by day and the pillar of fire by night. They were a redeemed people, bought by the blood of the lamb, led by the Shekinah glory—and they were complaining.

But this is not ordinary grumbling. **This is a mutiny of the appetite.** "And the mixt multitude that was among them fell a lusting: and the children of Israel also wept again, and said, Who shall give us flesh to eat? We remember the fish, which we did eat in Egypt freely; the cucumbers, and the melons, and the leeks, and the onions, and the garlick: But now our soul is dried away: there is nothing at all, beside this manna, before our eyes." (Numbers 11:4–6, KJV). Did you catch that? **They called manna—the bread of heaven, the very substance of divine sustenance—"nothing."** They dried up their own souls with the memory of onions. They traded the taste of glory for the nostalgia of slavery. They preferred the fleshpots of Egypt to the freedom of the wilderness, because the fleshpots were familiar and the wilderness required faith. And what did God do? He became angry. Moses became overwhelmed. And God said, "I will give you flesh, and ye shall eat. Ye shall not eat one day, nor two days, nor five days, neither ten days, nor twenty days; But even a

whole month, until it come out at your nostrils, and it be loathsome unto you." (Numbers 11:19–20, KJV).

Now follow the dreadfulness of this divine concession. God is not giving them quail as a gift of grace; He is giving them quail as a judgment. He is answering their prayer in its literal, carnal, unspiritual fullness—and that answer becomes the very instrument of their punishment. The miracle becomes a curse. The provision becomes a plague. The very thing they craved becomes the thing that kills them. Let us trace this terrifying thread through the rest of Scripture, because God does not change, and His ways with a rebellious heart are the same yesterday, today, and forever. We begin with the Psalms, which are the Spirit's commentary on Israel's wilderness history. Psalm 106:14–15 (KJV) compresses the entire tragedy into two devastating verses: "But lusted exceedingly in the wilderness, and tempted God in the desert. And he gave them their request; but sent leanness into their soul." The Psalmist says they "tempted God"—they tested His patience, they provoked His holiness. And He gave them their request. But in the very moment of the giving, He sent "leanness into their soul." While they were chewing the quail, their spirits were shriveling. While their mouths were full, their hearts were empty. That is the anatomy of divine anger: God gives you the thing you demanded, but He removes the blessing from the gift, so that you choke on your own answered prayer.

Now look at the tragedy of Balaam. Numbers 22 tells us the prophet was hired by Balak to curse Israel. He wanted the money, he wanted the honor, he wanted the prestige. God told him not to go, but he went anyway. And God let him go—but sent an angel with a drawn sword to kill him on the road. The permission was not favor; it was fury. God said, "Go, if you are so determined to ruin yourself," and Balaam walked straight into death with divine permission. That is the pattern: when we insist on our own way, God may withdraw His restraining hand and say, "Behold, I have given you your desire; now eat the fruit of it." **Consider the parable of the prodigal son. He demanded his inheritance—his portion of the living—while his father was still alive. That was a cultural obscenity, a virtual declaration that the father was dead to him. And the father gave it. He did not argue, he did not plead, he did not chain the boy to the house. He divided the living and let him go.** And the son wasted it all in riotous living, until he was so hungry he envied the pigs. That was the "yes" of the father—a yes that let the boy hit bottom, because the only way to cure a craving for the far country is to let the far country empty your pockets and break your teeth on husks.

And we cannot ignore the New Testament warning in Romans. Paul, writing of the gentiles who rejected the knowledge of God, says: "Wherefore God also gave them up to uncleanness through the lusts of their own hearts... And even as they did not like to retain God in their knowledge, God gave them over to a reprobate mind." (Romans 1:24, 28, KJV).

Three times Paul writes the dreadful phrase "God gave them up." He stopped wrestling, He stopped warning, He stopped interfering, and He let them have exactly what they wanted—and in having it, they were damned. The scariest judgment of all is not fire from heaven; it is the silence of God who says, "Fine. Have it your way."

Now, we must ask the hard question: What is the "quail" in your life? What is the thing you are asking God for, not because it is His will, but because your flesh is screaming for it?

What is the "onion" and the "garlic" of Egypt that your memory has romanticized, while you despise the manna of God's daily provision? For some of you, it is a relationship that God has closed, but you keep begging Him to open it. For some, it is a career path that will destroy your soul, but you are willing to trade your birthright for the pottage. For some, it is a bitter root of unforgiveness that you are nursing, a resentment you are cultivating, a sin you are protecting. You have been praying, "God, give me this!"—and God is silent. That silence may be mercy. Because when He finally says yes to your idol, He may send leanness into your soul.

Let us bring the crescendo to its peak. The quail arrived—a wind from the Lord brought them in from the sea, three feet deep around the camp. The people gathered, they slaughtered, they spread them out, they feasted. And "while the flesh was yet between their teeth, ere it was chewed, the wrath of the LORD was kindled against the people, and the LORD smote the people with a very great plague." (Numbers 11:33). The meat was still in their mouths. They hadn't even swallowed the second bite. And the wrath of God fell like a hammer. **That place was named Kibroth-hattaavah—the graves of craving. They were buried with their teeth full. Can you see the horror? God did not wait until they had finished their feast. He struck them in the middle of the very act of consumption. The blessing that they had begged for became the shovel that dug their graves. Why? Because He will not share His glory with an idol. He will not let the creature worship the gift rather than the Giver. And when we demand that He serve our appetites rather than we serve His purposes, He may give us the rope and watch us hang ourselves.**

But here is the hinge of grace: this story is not just a warning; it is a signpost to the Cross. The quail was a judgment because Israel wanted bread without the Giver. But Jesus says, "I am the bread of life: he that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst." (John 6:35, KJV). **The manna they despised was a type of Christ. They preferred the fleshpots of Egypt to the living bread from heaven, just as the world today prefers the cheap thrills of sin to the costly grace of the Savior. But the true manna—Jesus—was given not to satisfy a craving, but to save a soul. He did not come to give you what you want; He came to give you what you need. And what you need is not quail; it is the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.**

And notice the difference: the quail was eaten and the people died. But the bread of heaven is eaten and we live forever. Jesus says, "Whoso eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, hath eternal life; and I will raise him up at the last day." (John 6:54, KJV). The old craving led to plague and graves; the new craving—hunger for righteousness—leads to resurrection and glory. So, beloved, examine your prayers. **James writes, "Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss, that ye may consume it upon your lusts." (James 4:3, KJV). That is the test: are you asking for God's glory or for your own gratification? If you are asking for quail, He may give it—and you will regret it forever. But if you are asking for Christ, He will give Him, and you will have everything.**

The climax of this sermon is not fear; it is surrender. The antidote to craving is not self-denial for its own sake; it is Christ-satisfaction. When the psalmist says, "Delight thyself also in the LORD; and he shall give thee the desires of thine heart" (Psalm 37:4, KJV), he is not saying God will give you whatever you want. He is saying God will change what you want so that your desires align with His—and then He gives you Himself, which is the only thing that ever truly satisfies. Let us learn the lesson of Kibroth-hattaavah. Do not pray for the meat between your teeth. Pray for the bread of life in your soul. Do not ask for your own will to be done. Ask, with Jesus, "Not my will, but thine, be done." (Luke 22:42, KJV). For when you yield your cravings to the cross, the wrath that fell on the quail-eaters falls instead on the Lamb—and you walk away not with leanness in your soul, but with the fullness of His Spirit.

The graves of craving are behind you. The table of the Lord is before you. Come, not with the demand of the belly, but with the hunger of the heart. For He satisfies the longing soul, and filleth the hungry soul with goodness. (Psalm 107:9, KJV). Amen.